Is It a Task or a Decision?

A worksheet for turning what's on the family's mind into small next steps.

“We should think about the stairs” is a concern. “Ask Mom which rooms she uses most” is a task: someone can do it on a Saturday, and every choice is still open afterwards. A decision is different. It would commit Mom to something, and this page sets those to one side.

Take one concern at a time, and use a fresh copy for each. Write it the way it was said. Where you don't know something, write “don't know yet” and leave it.

The concern, the way it was said

One thing that's on someone's mind, in their words, with whose it is. The ones you disagree with belong here too.

FOR EXAMPLE “We should start looking at places before we have to.” My brother, at dinner in August.

What the family would like to have ready

Underneath the concern, what would be good to have in hand whatever happens later? Write something you could get ready, not something Mom would have to change.

FOR EXAMPLE We'd know what Mom wants from the place she lives, in her own words, long before anyone has to choose anything.

One small next step, and why you'd start there

Something one person could do in an afternoon: a phone call, a conversation, some reading, putting papers in a folder. Leave the name off for now.

FOR EXAMPLE Ask Mom what she likes most about her house and what she'd miss. Start there because nobody has asked her, and everything else depends on what she says.

Task or decision?

A task is something someone does. A decision is a choice that would commit Mom to something. Write which one your step is. If it turned out to be a decision, write it here as something the family is waiting on, then go back and look for the task inside it.

FOR EXAMPLE Asking Mom what she'd miss about her house: task. Choosing a place: decision. We're waiting on that one, not ruling it out.

What you'd need to know first

Anything that has to be asked or found out before the step makes sense. One per line.

FOR EXAMPLE Whether Mom wants to talk about this yet. My sister thinks she doesn't. Nobody has asked her.

Questions for a professional

Anything inside this concern the family can't answer itself. Don't answer it here. Write the question and who you'd take it to: her doctor, or your care consultant.

FOR EXAMPLE Whether the stairs are something to ask about. That's for her doctor, at her next regular visit. Mom said she'd raise it herself.

What this shows you

Three things: the small step inside each concern, which items are tasks and which are decisions the family is waiting on, and which questions belong to a professional. It doesn't show who should take a step or when, and it doesn't put the steps in order. Nothing here adds up to a score or a level, and no line on it decides anything for Mom.

Ready for the next step?

You've turned what was on the family's mind into small next steps, with the decisions set to one side. The care interview covers the ground those steps stand on: it walks you through Mom's situation as it is today, area by area, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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